

CHAPTER ONE: "THE LAST PAGE ISN'T IN THE SCRIPT"

March – May 2007

TIMELINE: AGES ON DAY ONE (MONDAY, MARCH 12, 2007)

Person	Born	Age
Kevin Feige	June 2, 1973	33
Avi Arad	Aug 1, 1948	58
Jon Favreau	Oct 19, 1966	40
Robert Downey Jr.	Apr 4, 1965	41 (42 on Apr 4)
Gwyneth Paltrow	Sept 27, 1972	34
Terrence Howard	Mar 11, 1969	38 (turned 38 yesterday)
Jeff Bridges	Dec 4, 1949	57
Samuel L. Jackson	Dec 21, 1948	58
Stan Lee	Dec 28, 1922	84

HOLLYWOOD TRADES

VARIETY | *Monday, March 12, 2007*

MARVEL UPS FEIGE TO PRODUCTION PREZ

Longtime Arad lieutenant takes the reins as indie studio's first self-financed pic, 'Iron Man,' begins lensing today.

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER | *March 12, 2007*

'IRON MAN' ROLLS: Downey suits up as Marvel bets \$140M on itself

Analysts question whether a comic company can survive without a studio's safety net. "If 'Iron Man' misses, Marvel's collateral is Captain America," said one financier. "Imagine explaining that to shareholders."

DEADLINE HOLLYWOOD DAILY (Nikki Finke) | *March 12, 2007, 9:14 PM PT*

TOLDJA: Marvel's Beverly Hills skeleton crew is making a play

Sources say Maisel's Merrill Lynch money comes with 10 characters attached. Why is a company making ONE movie locking actors into NINE-picture deals? Somebody over the Mercedes dealership is thinking big. Or crazy.

THE FANS

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM FORUMS › *Iron Man (2008)* › "PRINCIPAL PHOTOGRAPHY BEGINS — DISCUSSION THREAD"

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ShellHead_1963 — *Mar 12 2007, 10:02 AM*

IT'S HAPPENING. Downey is Tony. I've said it since September. The man IS a recovering genius disaster. Casting of the decade.

XxWolverineXx — *Mar 12 2007, 10:09 AM*

lol ok. B-list hero, a guy nobody's hired since Ally McBeal, and a studio that's never made a movie. See you at the \$90M opening. Domestic TOTAL.

Rhodey4WarMachine — *Mar 12 2007, 10:31 AM*

Terrence Howard as Rhodey. Pay attention to him. Mark my words, we see the silver suit by the sequel.

ExcelsiorFaithful — *Mar 12 2007, 11:47 AM*

Only thing I care about: IS IT COMIC ACCURATE? Stane better BE Iron Monger. Don't give me some made-up villain.

Mjolnir_Worthy — *Mar 12 2007, 12:20 PM*

Weird question. Marvel ALSO has Hulk shooting this summer with Norton. Two movies, same year, same studio. Anyone else think they're connected?

XxWolverineXx — *Mar 12 2007, 12:22 PM*

@Mjolnir_Worthy no. That's not how movies work. Different directors, different casts. Studios don't do that. Calm down.

TWITTER (*SXSW Interactive, Austin, TX. Twitter's usage explodes this week*)

@geekdad_atx — *4:51 PM Mar 12th, 2007*

at SXSW, everyone twittering about twitter. meanwhile Iron Man started filming today and nobody here cares. wrong room.

SCENE 1

EXT. OWENS VALLEY / LONE PINE, CALIFORNIA — "AFGHANISTAN" CAVE SET — DAY
MONDAY, MARCH 12, 2007 — 6:47 AM PT

Wind rips across the Alabama Hills. Red rock. Real dust. A real cave mouth, dressed with real Stark Industries crates. No green screen anywhere.

A 90-pound suit of hammered, bolted steel, the MARK I, stands on a stand. It's practical, it weighs what it looks like it

weighs, and it is ugly on purpose.

JON FAVREAU (40), director, baseball cap, walkie on his hip, circles it like it's a car he's thinking about buying.

ROBERT DOWNEY JR. (41) walks up in a torn, bloodstained tank top, drinking a green smoothie. He knocks on the chest plate. It CLANGS.

DOWNEY
That's real.

FAVREAU
That's real.

DOWNEY
I'm going to be inside that.

FAVREAU
You said no stunt double. I wrote it down. I had it notarized.

DOWNEY
(grinning)
I say a lot of things at 6 AM.

He runs his hand along a weld seam, then gets serious.

DOWNEY (CONT'D)
Tony built this in a cave. With scraps. With a box of scraps. If it looks like a stunt guy is in there, the whole movie's a lie.

FAVREAU
So you're in.

DOWNEY
I've been out for ten years, Jon. I'm in.

A STUNT COORDINATOR hustles over with a harness rig.

STUNT COORDINATOR
We rigged it for his weight plus ninety. Two guys on safety lines. If he goes down, he goes down slow.

DOWNEY
Story of my career.

SCENE 2

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS — 9242 BEVERLY BLVD — SECOND FLOOR — DAY
MONDAY, MARCH 12, 2007 — 10:15 AM PT

Downstairs, through the floor, a Mercedes salesman is closing a deal. Up here: cramped offices, a coffee maker from 1994, long boxes of comics stacked against every wall.

KEVIN FEIGE (33), Angels cap, bottle of Diet Coke, stands in front of a WHITEBOARD taped over with butcher paper.

DAVID MAISEL (mid-40s, suit, no tie) closes the door and locks it.

MAISEL
Congratulations, Mr. President
of Production.

FEIGE
Variety spelled my name right.
That's a first.

MAISEL
Show me.

Feige tears the paper down.

Underneath: TEN CHARACTER NAMES, the Merrill Lynch collateral, plus IRON MAN, HULK and THOR in red marker. Arrows everywhere. All of them lead to one word circled three times in the middle:

AVENGERS

FEIGE
Eight films. Four and a half
years. Every one of them stands
on its own. You could walk into
any of them cold and you'd love
it.

(beat)
And every one of them is a
chapter.

MAISEL
The bank thinks we're making one
movie about a guy in a tin can.

FEIGE

The bank is right. For now.

MAISEL

Ike is going to ask what this costs.

FEIGE

It costs nothing extra. That's the trick. We're making these movies anyway. We just make them in the same world. Same S.H.I.E.L.D., same scientists, same timeline. Tony's Arc reactor exists in the Hulk movie. Nobody has to notice. Until they do.

Maisel steps closer. He sees something in the lower-right corner of the board, a small sketch in purple marker:

A GAUNTLET. SIX EMPTY SLOTS.

MAISEL

What's that?

FEIGE

That's 2019.

MAISEL

(laughs)

Kevin. We might not exist in 2009.

FEIGE

Then it won't matter. But if we do...

(taps the glove)

Starlin. The Infinity Gauntlet. Thanos wipes out half the universe to impress Death because he's in love with her. We do it exactly like the comic. No watered-down version. No "he wants to save resources." He's a nihilist in love with a goddess.

MAISEL

You're going to pitch Paramount a love story between a purple alien and the Grim Reaper.

FEIGE

I'm not pitching anybody anything.
(beat)

That's rule one. Nobody outside this room says "universe." Not to agents, not to the trades, not to the actors. The contracts say "sequel options." The audience finds this on their own.

MAISEL
And if they don't?

FEIGE
They will. Fans always do. The first time Nick Fury walks into Tony Stark's living room, some kid on a message board is going to lose his mind. And then he's going to tell a million people.

MAISEL
What's the project called?
Internally.

Feige looks at the long boxes along the wall. Decades of Stan's Soapbox columns.

FEIGE
Bullpen.

MAISEL
Project Bullpen.

FEIGE
Stan would like it.

Maisel heads for the door, then stops.

MAISEL
One more thing. Avi.

FEIGE
(quiet)
I know.

MAISEL
He built this place.

FEIGE
And he's going to leave it in

good hands. I'll make sure of that.

SCENE 3

INT. FAVREAU'S PRODUCTION TRAILER — LONE PINE — NIGHT
MONDAY, MARCH 12, 2007 — 8:40 PM PT

Favreau has storyboards spread across a folding table and is eating cold craft-services pasta. His flip phone BUZZES.
CALLER ID: "KEVIN F."

FAVREAU
Day one's in the can. Nobody died.
Downey was in the suit for eleven takes.

FEIGE (V.O.)
(over phone)
Eleven?

FAVREAU
He refused to come out. Said Tony wouldn't come out.

FEIGE (V.O.)
That's why we hired him.
(beat)
Jon, I need an extra page.

FAVREAU
We're locked. Paramount's got the script, the insurers have the script...

FEIGE (V.O.)
It's not in the script. It goes after the credits.

Favreau puts his fork down.

FAVREAU
After the credits. Nobody stays for that. The ushers are sweeping popcorn.

FEIGE (V.O.)
They'll stay for this one.
Samuel L. Jackson. Eye patch.

Cigar.
Tony's living room.

FAVREAU
(slow)
Nick Fury.

FEIGE (V.O.)
Jack Kirby's Fury. Sergeant of
the Howling Commandos, Normandy,
1944. The Infinity Formula keeps
him in his fifties for sixty
years. Every word of that
history comes straight from
the page.

FAVREAU
And Sam Jackson.

FEIGE (V.O.)
Sam Jackson is the one exception
I'll ever make to the page. The
history is 616. The face is Sam.
Nobody else has that authority
walking into a room.

FAVREAU
And he says what?

FEIGE (V.O.)
"I'm here to talk to you about
the Avengers Initiative."

A long silence. Favreau looks at the storyboard of the Mark I
he spent all day shooting.

FAVREAU
Kevin. What are we making?

FEIGE (V.O.)
A great Iron Man movie. That's
all it has to be.
(beat)
Skeleton crew. Fake slate. We'll
call it...
(beat)
"Rhodey's Birthday Party." Nobody
looks twice at that.

FAVREAU
(laughing)
Terrence's birthday was

yesterday.

FEIGE (V.O.)
Then it's authentic.

SCENE 4

INT. STAN LEE'S OFFICE — POW! ENTERTAINMENT — BEVERLY HILLS
WEDNESDAY, MARCH 21, 2007 — 2:00 PM PT

STAN LEE (84), in tinted glasses, is signing a stack of posters with a black Sharpie. FEIGE sits across from him holding a single envelope.

STAN
Kevin! The man in the hat! What brings the President of Production to see an old huckster?

FEIGE
Your cameo. Iron Man.

STAN
Tell me I'm Hugh Hefner. I've been practicing.

FEIGE
(smiles)
Close.
(slides the envelope over)
And one more thing. Just for you.
Read it and give it back.

Stan opens it. One page. He reads it. His Sharpie stops moving.

STAN
(softly)
All of them.

FEIGE
All of them.

STAN
Same world. Like the comics. Like 1963. The Fantastic Four in the Baxter Building and Spidey swinging past the window and the Hulk on the news...

FEIGE

Every one of them, Stan. We never sold a single one. Not Spidey, not the X-Men, not the Four. Everybody's still home.

STAN

(grinning)

Every studio in town laughed at us for turning down their money. Let's see who's laughing in 2019.

(hands the page back)

You know what we called it in the '60s? The Marvel Universe. The fans named it. We didn't. The kids wrote letters: "Hey Stan, is this the same New York where Daredevil lives?" And we said, "True Believer... it always was."

FEIGE

That's the plan. They name it. Not us.

STAN

Excelsior, kid.

HEADLINES: SPRING 2007

VARIETY | *Thursday, April 12, 2007*

NORTON'S 'HULK' SETS TORONTO SUMMER START; PARAMOUNT DISTRIBS

Leterrier helms the first live-action Hulk film. Marvel promises "the Hulk from the comics, with no limits on how strong he gets."

AIN'T IT COOL NEWS | *April 30, 2007*

Moriarty here with a WHISPER from the Iron Man set...

A little birdie says a "mystery day" is on the call sheet with a crew of about 12 people and a code name about a birthday party. Marvel won't comment. Somebody's cooking something, squirts.

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER | *Thursday, May 31, 2007*

ARAD EXITS MARVEL STUDIOS

Founder steps down to produce independently. Chairman Maisel and production chief Feige to steer the studio's slate.

COMICBOOKRESOURCES.COM | *May 31, 2007*

THE END OF AN ERA: What Arad's departure means for Marvel's movies

"Feige is the guy who knows the difference between Earth-616 and Earth-1610," said one source. "Fans should be very, very happy."

SCENE 5 (CLOSING)

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS – FEIGE'S OFFICE – NIGHT
THURSDAY, MAY 31, 2007 – 11:52 PM PT

The building is empty. The Mercedes showroom below is dark.

FEIGE (33) is alone. AVI ARAD's farewell card is propped on the desk: "Don't screw up my toys. – Avi."

Feige unlocks a bottom drawer and takes out a three-ring binder. Hand-lettered on the spine:

THE CODEX

He opens it. The first tab: IRON MAN – MAY 2, 2008.
Last tab, still blank except for a date:

MAY 2019

He picks up a purple marker and writes one line on the blank page:

"He courts Death. She never answers. That's the whole saga."

He closes the binder. Locks the drawer. Turns off the light.

In the dark, the whiteboard still shows the purple gauntlet sketch. Six empty slots.

CUT TO BLACK.

SUPER: "11 MONTHS UNTIL
IRON MAN OPENS."

(beat)

SUPER: "12 YEARS UNTIL HE SNAPS."

END OF CHAPTER ONE